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News Briefs

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SACRAMENTO

Author of AB 587 issues statement on District Court hearing regarding Twitter's challenge to landmark transparency measure

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), author of Assembly Bill (AB) 587, issued the following statement regarding today's hearing on the lawsuit by X, the company formerly known as Twitter, challenging the bill in federal court:

"I applaud Attorney General Bonta for his vigorous defense of AB 587, a straightforward transparency measure that simply requires social media companies to disclose basic information about if and how they are moderating content on their platforms," said Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel. "Consumers deserve to know the truth about these policies so that they can make informed decisions. If Elon Musk has nothing to hide, then he should have no objection to this bill."

AB 587 was first introduced in 2021, but took nearly two years to pass in the face of fierce opposition from major social media companies. The bill ultimately secured bipartisan support and passed the Legislature after an intense grassroots lobbying effort by more than 80 civil rights and civic organizations.

— Submitted

CALFIRE

$170 million available to promote thriving forest ecosystems

The California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection (CAL FIRE) is announcing the availability of up to $120 million for Forest Health and $50 million for Post-Fire Reforestation and Regeneration projects.

CAL FIRE is soliciting applications for projects that work to proactively prevent catastrophic wildfires and restore forests to healthy, functioning ecosystems while also sequestering carbon and reducing greenhouse gas emissions. Applications will be accepted will be due by no later than 3 PM on Jan. 15, 2024. Visit https://gn.ecivis.com/GO/gn_redir/T/qb5oi8zj4xe8 to apply.

"Forest Health grants continue to be an invaluable tool for funding restoration and reforestation activities that provide for more resilient and healthy forests across California," said Matthew Reischman, CAL FIRE Deputy Director of Resource Management.

The Forest Health Program funds active restoration and reforestation activities aimed at providing for more resilient and sustained forests. This ensures the future existence of forests in California while also mitigating climate change, protecting communities from fire risk, strengthening rural economies, and improving California's water and air.

A virtual pre-recorded workshop will be made available to explain the grant process and requirements.

Please check the Forest Health webpage to view the workshop. Any questions can be directed to ForestHealth@fire.ca.gov.

Projects that receive funding from the Forest Health grant program are designed to complement the California Forest Carbon Plan, California's Natural and Working Lands Implementation Plan, California's Wildfire & Forest Resilience Action Plan, California's Strategic Plan for Expanding the Use of Beneficial Fire, and AB 32 Climate Change Scoping Plan.

The Forest Health grant program is part of California Climate Investments, a statewide program that puts billions of cap-and-trade dollars to work reducing greenhouse gas emissions, strengthening the economy, and improving public health and the environment— particularly in disadvantaged communities.

—Submitted

LAKE COUNTY

Thompson presents $750,000 check to Lake County officials for Middle Creek flood restoration

On Monday, Rep. Mike Thompson (CA-04) presented a check for $750,000 to Lake County officials for restoration of Middle Creek flood infrastructure. The project will remove up to 40 percent of phosphorus entering Clear Lake from Middle and Scotts Creeks and reduce chlorophyll concentrations by 33 percent.

"Cleaning up the environment and protection from flooding is crucial to the health and safety of our community," said Thompson. "This restoration is critical to preserving Clear Lake, reducing the cost of treating our drinking water, and preventing severe flooding. Proud to have secured this funding for Lake County."

"There is no project more critical to sustainable Clear Lake water quality and a strong outdoor-recreation based Lake County economy than the Middle Creek Flood Damage Reduction and Ecosystem Restoration Project," emphasizes Eddie Crandell, Lake County's District 3 Supervisor. "Congressman Thompson understood completing final Feasibility Stage steps with the United States Army Corps of Engineers was highly urgent and essential to moving this project forward, and we were grateful he fought hard to ensure this work was funded."

"Clear Lake is one of the oldest lakes in North America, and it needs more wetland area to thrive," notes Marina Deligiannis, Deputy Water Resources Director for the County of Lake. "Current sediment and phosphorous loads are estimated to be twice the pre-European levels, and about 71% of the sediment and phosphorous entering Clear Lake comes from Scotts and Middle Creek watersheds. This project could reduce Clear Lake phosphorous levels by 40%, helping to preserve a national treasure. Thank you to Congressman Thompson for recognizing this as a matter of high federal priority."

The funding that Rep. Thompson secured will help facilitate the removal of three miles of substandard levees, one pumping station, and one weir structure. Removal of the structures would carry tremendous ecological benefits by improving Clear Lake water quality and storage capacity.

—Submitted

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